

January

20

2009

Obama presidency

Barack Obama was sworn in as the 44th president of the USA. He was the first Black person in history to be elected to the role. A lawyer and community organizer, he served as president for eight years.



1892

Basketball beginnings

Two teams at the YMCA school in Springfield, Massachusetts, USA, played the first official basketball match. The game had been thought up by their gym teacher.



1885

Roller-coaster ride

The first US patent for a roller-coaster design was given to La Marcus Thompson of Coney Island, USA. His switchback railway reached speeds of just 9 kph (6 mph).



Also on this day

1788 The first fleet of 736 British convicts and their jailers sailed into Botany Bay in Australia, where they established a penal colony.

1942 Nazi officials met to discuss the “Final Solution” – their plan to kill Europe’s Jews by sending them to extermination camps in Poland.

2014 Half of South Korea’s population fell victim to computer hacking when credit card details of around 20 million citizens were stolen.

Born this day

1910 Joy Adamson, Austrian naturalist. She carried out wildlife conservation work in Kenya, and raised an orphan lioness cub named Elsa, who was eventually released back into the wild.